

Objections to Williamson's View on Philosophical Progress

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Williamson poses the challenge: "But what is the point of asking a question, if you expect no progress in answering it?" To address this, one must consider the nature of the inquiry itself. If there is no possible answer to this specific question, then we have no logical basis to criticize those who ask questions without expecting progress, as the critique itself would be based on an unanswerable premise. Conversely, if an answer does exist, it would necessarily suggest that there is a purpose to such inquiries, thereby proving that asking the question was not a nonsensical act.

Progress as a Multidimensional Concept Beyond Positive Results.

Progress in philosophical or scientific inquiry does not exclusively mean arriving at a definitive positive result. On the contrary, the process of elimination—identifying that, certain statements or hypotheses do not provide the answer—is an essential form of progress. Furthermore, solving any problem consists of two distinct stages: the formulation of the question and the derivation of the answer. History shows that many foundational questions in fields such as physics (regarding the mechanics of the universe) and psychology (regarding the nature of the mind) did not receive immediate answers. However, without the initial act of questioning, these subjects would never have been established, and future solutions would have remained unreachable.

The Intrinsic Significance of Fundamental Existential Inquiries.

There exists a category of questions whose value is independent of whether a definitive answer can be found. Fundamental inquiries into the meaning of existence, ethics, morality, justice, love, and death—as well as the meta-question of whether it is worth asking questions without expecting progress—scarcely yield definite conclusions. Nevertheless, these are vital concerns. Their significance is derived from the act of thinking and the human condition they address, rather than the attainment of a final, settled answer.

The Unproven Foundations of Logic as a Model for Philosophical Significance.

Williamson cites logic as a primary example of progress made by philosophy. However, logic is not as definitive as he suggests. The fundamental laws of logic—such as the Law of Identity, the Law of Non-Contradiction, the Law of Excluded Middle, and the Law of Sufficient Reason—are foundational axioms that are not, and perhaps cannot be proven in a traditional sense. If Williamson admits that logic represents a significant advancement in philosophy despite its unproven foundations, he must also concede that other inquiries can be significant even when they do not lead to a "definite" or "proven" answer.